Passing the Flame

Othello, or the trap of theatrical illusion. Ten lessons, the spirale de Gorse, a midpoint commentary and a summative assessment.

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Tle spécialité LLCER · lycée général et technologique · Level C1

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Théodore Chassériau, Othello et Desdémone à Venise, 1849-1850, oil on wood, Musée du Louvre, Paris, RF 3897, public domain.

Guiding question

How does Shakespeare turn theatre itself into a trap of perception in Othello, and what does that trap still teach us about language, jealousy and the courage to read between the lines?

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Aim of the sequence and the five language activities

Aim. To read Shakespeare's *Othello* at C1 as a play about the trap of theatrical illusion.

The work asks how language, objects and staged looking can be made to mean what a speaker has already decided they mean. It prepares students for hypokhâgne and the first year of a Licence LLCER. It does not pretend to be those courses.

Guiding question. How does Shakespeare turn theatre itself into a trap of perception in *Othello*, and what does that trap still teach us about language, jealousy and the courage to read between the lines?

Objectives, organised by the five activités langagières

Compréhension de l'écrit

- Read complete speeches in verse, with line numbers, and say what each movement does.
- Track dramatic irony, aside, metaphor, sententia, and the meaning forced onto an object.
- Read short public-domain critics and answer them with evidence from the play.

Compréhension de l'oral

- Follow a five-minute video essay and note what it asks us to inherit as a way of reading.
- Listen to verse spoken aloud (stress, pause, address) and test one staging choice against the line.

Expression écrite

- Write short, accurate records, then a midpoint commentary and a summative commentary, with a precise thesis and quotations.
- Compare one passage with François-Victor Hugo's public-domain French, in English.

Expression orale en continu

- Present a short close-reading claim (40 to 60 seconds) with one quotation.
- Deliver a short director's commentary in Lesson 10.

Interaction orale

- Direct a fragment in pairs. Justify one decision from the verse.
- Debate a critic or a hypothesis without leaving the text.

Level. C1 throughout: close reading of verse, control of critical vocabulary, and a first approach to the commentary practised in classe préparatoire. The demand is not divided into a lower tier and a later extension.

Text. All quotations follow a public-domain English text (Project Gutenberg ebook 1531). Line numbers in this booklet are those of that file. In class, you may align them with the Folger Shakespeare Library Digital Text. Translation work uses only François-Victor Hugo, *Othello ou le More de Venise* (public domain). Yves Bonnefoy and Jean-Michel Déprats are not used.

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Dédicace

« À la mémoire du Professeur Pierre Spriet,

et à tous mes maîtres des classes préparatoires et de l'Université Bordeaux III,

qui m'ont appris à lire le monde entre les lignes.

Aux artistes de la Royal Shakespeare Company (Stratford-upon-Avon, 1984-85),

qui m'ont montré que l'amour du texte rend les êtres meilleurs.

Aux élèves de Terminale qui s'apprêtent à entrer en Hypokhâgne ou en Licence d'Anglais :

puisse cette flamme devenir la vôtre. »

Note d’intention

Ce dossier est né d’un élan de gratitude. Il ne prétend à aucun titre académique : il est le témoignage d’une amoureuse des mots, de la langue anglaise et de la langue française, dont toute la vie intérieure a été éclairée par des passeurs généreux. À travers une étude approfondie du piège théâtral dans Othello et quatre explications de texte modèles (dont la scène d’espionnage de l’Acte IV, scène 1), il invite les futurs étudiants à découvrir que la littérature n’est jamais un savoir mort, mais une école de lucidité et d’humanité.

How this sequence is organised

Ten lessons of 55 minutes, timed on 52.

In every lesson a **stopping point** falls at about minute 44. The last eight minutes can complete the main task, or open an **emergency exit**: a shorter close, still demanding, that leaves no student without a finished thought.

Each lesson has a spoken turn, a written record, a vocabulary rubric titled **Expanding your vocabulary** or **Building your vocabulary**, a short grammar focus, and homework.

British English is used throughout, including in the teacher’s notes.

The midpoint assessment sits after Lesson 5. Lesson 10 is the summative hour.

A five-minute video essay by Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac opens the work.

The phrase « spirale de Gorse » is kept in French, as the name of the method. Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.

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The ten turns of the spiral

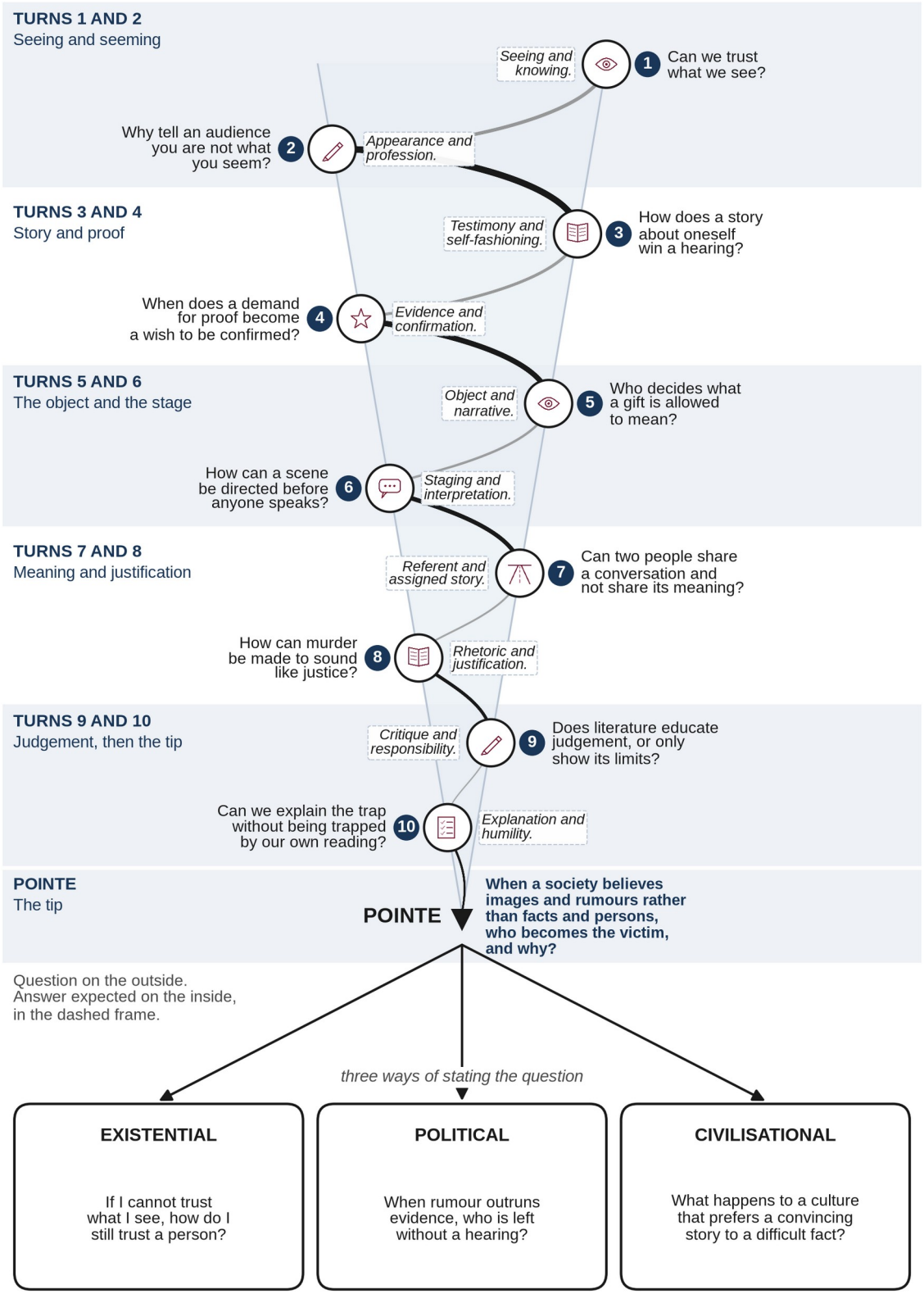


Diagram of the spirale de Gorse: ten turns tighten towards a tip, which opens into three paths, existential, political and civilisational.
Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.

The method is the spirale de Gorse. Ten turns tighten towards a tip. The tip then opens into three paths: existential, political and civilisational.

1. Can we trust what we see? Seeing and knowing.
2. Why tell an audience you are not what you seem? Appearance and profession.

3. How does a story about oneself win a hearing? Testimony and self-fashioning.
4. When does a demand for proof become a wish to be confirmed? Evidence and confirmation.
5. Who decides what a gift is allowed to mean? Object and narrative.
6. How can a scene be directed before anyone speaks? Staging and interpretation.
7. Can two people share a conversation and not share its meaning? Referent and assigned story.
8. How can murder be made to sound like justice? Rhetoric and justification.
9. Does literature educate judgement, or only show its limits? Critique and responsibility.
10. Can we explain the trap without being trapped by our own reading? Explanation and humility.

The tip. When a society believes images and rumours rather than facts and persons, who becomes the victim, and why?

- **Existential.** If I cannot trust what I see, how do I still trust a person?
- **Political.** When rumour outruns evidence, who is left without a hearing?
- **Civilisational.** What happens to a culture that prefers a convincing story to a difficult fact?

Map of the ten lessons

1. Inheriting a way of reading. The video, the dedication, Chassériau, the spiral, a diagnostic.
2. Iago's invitation: « I am not what I am » (I.1).
3. The Senate: a story that wins a hearing (I.3).
4. The desire for proof (III.3).
5. The handkerchief and the test of trust (III.4). Midpoint assessment after this lesson.
6. Directing the spectator (IV.1).
7. One conversation, two meanings.
8. The language of justification (V.2).
9. What can literature teach? Public-domain critics, Hugo, a debate.
10. Explaining the trap. Summative commentary and a short director's commentary.

Lesson 1. Inheriting a way of reading

Turn. Can we trust what we see? Seeing and knowing.

Aim. To inherit a way of reading: look carefully first, then interpret. To meet the painting, the spiral and the guiding question.



Théodore Chassériau, Othello et Desdémone à Venise, 1849-1850, oil on wood, Musée du Louvre, Paris, RF 3897, public domain.

Credit. Théodore Chassériau, *Othello et Desdémone à Venise*, 1849-1850, oil on wood, Musée du Louvre, Paris, RF 3897, public domain.

> ***Before you look for a story.*** *What do you actually see: place, light, distance, hands, eyes? What can the painting not prove?*

Your tasks

1. Watch the five-minute video essay. Note three things it asks us to inherit as a way of reading. Do not summarise the biography.
2. Look at the painting for two full minutes before you write. Then complete, in short sentences:

- In the foreground I can see… - The two figures are… - The light falls… - This painting cannot prove…

1. Read the dedication and the note d'intention (they remain in French). In two sentences, say what « passing the flame » might mean for a reader of *Othello*.
2. Choose one turn of the spiral. Write why it already seems useful, in no more than three lines.

Speaking turn. Forty seconds: one precise observation about the painting, and one thing the image cannot prove.

Written record. The four sentences of task 2, fairly copied.

Building your vocabulary

Word	Use it to say
foreground / background	where a figure stands in the picture
to look / to gaze / to watch	different ways of seeing
theatrical illusion	a meaning arranged to be believed
to inherit a reading	to receive a method, not only a plot
diagnostic	a first test of what we can already do

Grammar for commentary

A cautious claim: *The painting suggests… It does not prove…*

Stopping point (minute 44) · Emergency exit

Complete only: *In this picture I can see… The two figures… This image cannot prove…*

Homework

1. Fair copy of today's written record (the four sentences, plus one on the guiding question).
2. Read I.1, Iago's speech from « O, sir, content you » to « I am not what I am ». Learn the last five lines by heart, accurately.

Towards a first model (short)

A useful first claim: Chassériau paints closeness and unease, not the plot of the play.

The man and the woman share a Venetian interior, but they do not share one easy meaning. A C1 comment names what is visible (gesture, light, distance) and then stops, honestly, at what the oil cannot tell us.

The sequence will ask the same honesty of Shakespeare's theatre: a scene can be arranged so that looking feels like knowing.

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Lesson 2. Iago's invitation: « I am not what I am »

Turn. Why tell an audience you are not what you seem? Appearance and profession.

Aim. To read Iago's contract with the spectator as a complete speech, and to say what the last line does.

Before you read. *Why would a character tell us, so early, that he is not what he is? What does that invitation do to us, as an audience?*

I.1, Iago, to Roderigo. *(Gutenberg ebook 1531, lines 133-157.)*

O, sir, content you.
I follow him to serve my turn upon him:
We cannot all be masters, nor all masters
Cannot be truly follow'd. You shall mark
Many a duteous and knee-crooking knave
That, doting on his own obsequious bondage,
Wears out his time, much like his master's ass,
For nought but provender, and when he's old, cashier'd.
Whip me such honest knaves. Others there are
Who, trimm'd in forms, and visages of duty,
Keep yet their hearts attending on themselves,
And throwing but shows of service on their lords,
Do well thrive by them, and when they have lin'd their coats,
Do themselves homage. These fellows have some soul,
And such a one do I profess myself. For, sir,
It is as sure as you are Roderigo,
Were I the Moor, I would not be Iago:
In following him, I follow but myself.
Heaven is my judge, not I for love and duty,
But seeming so for my peculiar end.
For when my outward action doth demonstrate
The native act and figure of my heart
In complement extern, 'tis not long after
But I will wear my heart upon my sleeve
For daws to peck at: I am not what I am.

Glosses

Phrase	A short help
to serve my turn upon him	to use him for my own purpose
knee-crooking knave	a servant who bows too readily
provender	food for an animal; mere keep
cashier'd	dismissed, thrown off
visages of duty	faces, or masks, of loyalty

Phrase	A short help
complement extern	the outward show that matches an inner act
daws	jackdaws; stupid birds, here ready to peck

Your tasks

1. Divide the speech into three movements. Give each movement a four-word title.
2. Underline every word that names a *show* or a *mask* (forms, visages, shows, seeming, outward, sleeve…).
3. In four short sentences, say:

- what Iago claims honest servants are; - what he claims the other sort are; - which sort he joins; - what the last clause does to the audience.

1. The line « I am not what I am » inverts a biblical formula of being. In three lines, say what is gained by ending on that inversion, rather than on a simple « I am a villain ».

Speaking turn. In pairs, speak the last five lines twice: once as a confidential pact, once as a boast. One decision about pause or address, justified from the verse.

Written record. 180 to 200 words: « What kind of contract does Iago offer the spectator in this speech? »

Expanding your vocabulary

to profess; seeming; peculiar (here: private, particular); outward / native; to wear one's heart on one's sleeve; dramatic irony; to take someone into one's confidence; inversion.

Grammar for commentary

Name the device, then its effect: *The inversion « I am not what I am » does not only confess a lie; it invites the spectator into a pact of knowing*.

Stopping point · Emergency exit

Four sentences only: *Iago divides servants into… He professes himself… The last line… The audience is invited to…*

Homework

1. Fair copy of the written record (200 words, C1).
2. Read I.3, from « Her father lov'd me » to « This only is the witchcraft I have us'd », and the close of the scene (« Look to her, Moor » / « My life upon her faith »).

After your own reading: a model in short moves

Read this only after your own attempt.

1. The speech is a profession, and a cancellation of profession. Iago first paints the « honest knave », then the man who keeps « shows of service », then joins the second group.
2. « In following him, I follow but myself » is already the method of the play: service as a mask for a private end.
3. The last five lines raise the mask into a law. If outward action ever showed the heart, Iago says, he would be exposed to « daws ». So he will not show it.
4. « I am not what I am » is the contract. The audience is flattered: we think we know. That flattery is already a trap.

Lesson 3. The Senate: a story that wins a hearing

Turn. How does a story about oneself win a hearing? Testimony and self-fashioning.

Aim. To read Othello's tale before the Senate as a complete speech, then the two lines that plant a future doubt.

> ***Before you read.*** *How can a story about danger and pity win a public hearing, and even a marriage? What, in the telling, is already theatre?*

I.3, Othello, before the Senate. *(Gutenberg 1531, lines 799-840.)*

Her father lov'd me, oft invited me,
Still question'd me the story of my life,
From year to year, the battles, sieges, fortunes,
That I have pass'd.
I ran it through, even from my boyish days
To the very moment that he bade me tell it,
Wherein I spake of most disastrous chances,
Of moving accidents by flood and field;
Of hair-breadth scapes i' th' imminent deadly breach;
Of being taken by the insolent foe,
And sold to slavery, of my redemption thence,
And portance in my traveler's history,
Wherein of antres vast and deserts idle,
Rough quarries, rocks, and hills whose heads touch heaven,
It was my hint to speak, such was the process;
And of the Cannibals that each other eat,
The Anthropophagi, and men whose heads
Do grow beneath their shoulders. This to hear
Would Desdemona seriously incline.
But still the house affairs would draw her thence,
Which ever as she could with haste dispatch,
She'd come again, and with a greedy ear
Devour up my discourse; which I observing,
Took once a pliant hour, and found good means
To draw from her a prayer of earnest heart
That I would all my pilgrimage dilate,
Whereof by parcels she had something heard,
But not intentively. I did consent,
And often did beguile her of her tears,
When I did speak of some distressful stroke
That my youth suffer'd. My story being done,
She gave me for my pains a world of sighs.
She swore, in faith, 'twas strange, 'twas passing strange;
'Twas pitiful, 'twas wondrous pitiful.
She wish'd she had not heard it, yet she wish'd
That heaven had made her such a man: she thank'd me,
And bade me, if I had a friend that lov'd her,
I should but teach him how to tell my story,
And that would woo her. Upon this hint I spake:
She lov'd me for the dangers I had pass'd,
And I lov'd her that she did pity them.

This only is the witchcraft I have us'd.

Glosses

Word or phrase	A short help
still question'd me	kept asking me
hair-breadth scapes	escapes by a very small margin
portance	bearing; the way he carried himself
antres	caves
deserts idle	empty deserts
Anthropophagi	eaters of human flesh, in travellers' tales
pliant hour	a favourable, flexible moment
to dilate	to tell at full length
by parcels	in fragments, not as a whole
to beguile her of her tears	to draw tears from her, almost by charm

Before you read the close. *A public story has just won a hearing. What can a single warning still plant in the mind that has been persuaded?*

I.3, the close. *(Gutenberg 1531, lines 1017-1025.)*

BRABANTIO.
Look to her, Moor, if thou hast eyes to see:
She has deceiv'd her father, and may thee.

OTHELLO.
My life upon her faith! Honest Iago,
My Desdemona must I leave to thee.

Glosses

Phrase	A short help
Look to her	watch her; take care
She has deceiv'd her father, and may thee	a future planted as a warning
My life upon her faith	I stake my life on her loyalty

Your tasks

1. In the long tale, mark three kinds of material: fact of service, travellers' wonders, and Desdemona's listening. Give one quotation for each.
2. Copy the chiasmus (« She lov'd me… / And I lov'd her… »). In two sentences, say how the two loves are balanced, and what that balance is made to explain.
3. « This only is the witchcraft I have us'd. » In three lines: what charge is he answering, and how does the tale itself work as a proof?

4. Brabantio's warning is a *prolepsis* (a future planted now). Othello answers with an absolute pledge. In four sentences, say how these two voices will be usable later in the trap.

Speaking turn. Speak the chiasmus and the next line, then Brabantio's two lines. One choice of pace, justified.

Written record. 200 to 220 words: « How does Othello's tale win a hearing, and what does Brabantio plant at the close? »

Expanding your vocabulary

testimony; self-fashioning; hypotyposis (a vivid scene made present in words); chiasmus; prolepsis; to win a hearing; witchcraft (here, a charge of charm); to stake one's life; faith (loyalty, and belief).

Grammar for commentary

Name a figure, then what it *does*: *The chiasmus makes two loves look like one cause.*

Stopping point · Emergency exit

The tale wins a hearing because… The chiasmus… Brabantio plants… Othello answers by…

Homework

1. Fair copy (220 words).
2. Read III.3, from Iago's « O, beware, my lord, of jealousy » to « Give me the ocular proof ».

After your own reading: a model in short moves

1. The speech is not a private confession. It is a public performance of a life, offered as evidence.
2. Wonders (antres, Anthropophagi) sit beside service. The mix makes the life both honourable and extraordinary. That is already a kind of theatre.
3. Desdemona is first a listener with a « greedy ear ». The tale includes her hearing as part of its proof.
4. The chiasmus seals the argument: her love for his dangers, his love for her pity. « This only is the witchcraft » turns storytelling into a legal answer.
5. Brabantio's couplet is brief and durable. « My life upon her faith » is generous, and it hands Iago a tool: absolute trust, spoken in public, next to « Honest Iago ».

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Lesson 4. The desire for proof

Turn. When does a demand for proof become a wish to be confirmed? Evidence and confirmation.

Aim. To read two complete movements in III.3: the « green-ey'd monster », then the demand for « ocular proof ».

Before you read. *What is the difference between wanting to know, and wanting to be confirmed? Listen for that shift.*

III.3, Iago and Othello. *(Gutenberg 1531, lines 2805-2823.)*

OTHELLO.
By heaven, I'll know thy thoughts.

IAGO.
You cannot, if my heart were in your hand,
Nor shall not, whilst 'tis in my custody.

OTHELLO.
Ha?

IAGO.
O, beware, my lord, of jealousy;
It is the green-ey'd monster which doth mock
The meat it feeds on. That cuckold lives in bliss
Who, certain of his fate, loves not his wronger;
But O, what damned minutes tells he o'er
Who dotes, yet doubts, suspects, yet strongly loves!

OTHELLO.
O misery!

III.3, later: the demand. *(Gutenberg 1531, lines 3156-3168.)*

OTHELLO.
Villain, be sure thou prove my love a whore;
Be sure of it. Give me the ocular proof,
Or, by the worth of man's eternal soul,
Thou hadst been better have been born a dog
Than answer my wak'd wrath.

IAGO.
Is't come to this?

OTHELLO.
Make me to see't, or at the least so prove it,
That the probation bear no hinge nor loop
To hang a doubt on, or woe upon thy life!

Glosses

Word or phrase	A short help
the green-ey'd monster	jealousy, given a body that feeds on what it looks at
the meat it feeds on	the person (or love) it consumes
to dote	to love foolishly, too fondly
ocular proof	proof that can be seen
probation	the test, the proving
no hinge nor loop to hang a doubt on	a proof with no room left for uncertainty

A third movement, if time. *(Gutenberg 1531, lines 2967-2989.) Othello alone, after Iago has left:*

Haply, for I am black,
And have not those soft parts of conversation
That chamberers have, or for I am declin'd
Into the vale of years, yet that's not much,
She's gone, I am abus'd…
If she be false, O, then heaven mocks itself!
I'll not believe't.

Glosses: *haply* (perhaps); *haggard / jesses* (falconry: a wild hawk, and the straps on its legs); *chamberers* (smooth courtly men).

Your tasks

1. In the first extract, who asks to know, and who refuses? Copy the sentence that turns knowledge into a warning about jealousy.
2. The monster « mocks the meat it feeds on ». In three lines, say what this metaphor *does* (not only what it means).

3. In the second extract, list the verbs of proof (*prove*, *see*, *probation*…). Then answer: is Othello still asking to know, or asking to have a doubt closed?
4. Optional, the soliloquy: what reasons does Othello try out (*haply… or for…*)? What happens to those reasons before « I'll not believe't »?

Speaking turn. The four lines from « Give me the ocular proof » to « wak'd wrath ». One decision about volume, justified.

Written record. 200 words: « In III.3, how does a wish to know become a wish to be confirmed? »

Expanding your vocabulary

jealousy; to mock; to dote / to doubt / to suspect; ocular; probation; hinge; confirmation; soliloquy; to over-read a sign.

Grammar for commentary

A change of desire: *What begins as « I'll know thy thoughts » ends as a demand that proof « bear no hinge nor loop to hang a doubt on »*.

Stopping point · Emergency exit

Iago names jealousy as… Othello then demands… « Ocular proof » means… The wish has changed from… to…

Homework

1. Fair copy (200 words).
2. Read all of III.4, from « Where should I lose that handkerchief, Emilia? » to « Heaven keep that monster from Othello's mind! ». The next lesson will print the main speeches whole; the whole scene must be known.

Notes towards the midpoint (short)

After Lesson 5 you will write a timed commentary on III.4. Keep today's vocabulary (*ocular proof*, *probation*, *to over-read*) ready. The handkerchief will not be a new cause. It will be an object onto which this method is forced.

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Lesson 5. The handkerchief and the test of trust

Turn. Who decides what a gift is allowed to mean? Object and narrative.

Aim. To give III.4 a full close reading. The main speeches are printed whole. Read the whole scene in your edition as well.

The theme that binds the movements is trust: Othello's trust in Desdemona; Desdemona's trust that truth will be enough; Emilia's trust that silence can still serve two loyalties.

> ***Before you read.*** *The audience already knows that Emilia has taken the handkerchief (III.3). What kind of listening does that knowledge force on us now?*

III.4, the opening and the moist hand. *(Gutenberg 1531, lines 3410-3470.)*

DESDEMONA.
Where should I lose that handkerchief, Emilia?

EMILIA.
I know not, madam.

DESDEMONA.
Believe me, I had rather have lost my purse
Full of crusadoes. And but my noble Moor
Is true of mind and made of no such baseness
As jealous creatures are, it were enough
To put him to ill thinking.

EMILIA.
Is he not jealous?

DESDEMONA.
Who, he? I think the sun where he was born
Drew all such humours from him.

EMILIA.
Look, where he comes.

Enter Othello.

DESDEMONA.
I will not leave him now till Cassio
Be call'd to him. How is't with you, my lord?

OTHELLO.
Well, my good lady. [Aside.] O, hardness to dissemble!
How do you, Desdemona?

DESDEMONA.
Well, my good lord.

OTHELLO.
Give me your hand. This hand is moist, my lady.

DESDEMONA.
It yet hath felt no age nor known no sorrow.

OTHELLO.
This argues fruitfulness and liberal heart.
Hot, hot, and moist. This hand of yours requires
A sequester from liberty, fasting and prayer,
Much castigation, exercise devout;
For here's a young and sweating devil here
That commonly rebels. 'Tis a good hand,
A frank one.

DESDEMONA.
You may indeed say so,
For 'twas that hand that gave away my heart.

OTHELLO.
A liberal hand. The hearts of old gave hands,
But our new heraldry is hands, not hearts.

DESDEMONA.
I cannot speak of this. Come now, your promise.

Glosses

Word or phrase	A short help
crusadoes	Portuguese gold coins
true of mind	loyal, not given to jealousy
humours	in early medicine, bodily fluids thought to shape temperament
aside	a private line, beside the public word
to dissemble	to hide what one thinks, to play a face
moist	in humoral language, a sign of desire and fruitfulness
liberal	generous, and also unrestrained
sequester	a setting apart, a withdrawal
frank	open, generous
heraldry	the language of coats of arms; signs that claim to guarantee honour

Before you read the history of the gift. *A love-token is about to be given a sacred and threatening origin. Who, in this telling, decides what the gift is allowed to mean?*

III.4, the handkerchief's tale, and the hypothetical. *(Gutenberg 1531, lines 3498-3550.)*

OTHELLO.
That is a fault. That handkerchief
Did an Egyptian to my mother give.
She was a charmer, and could almost read
The thoughts of people. She told her, while she kept it,
'Twould make her amiable and subdue my father
Entirely to her love. But if she lost it,
Or made a gift of it, my father's eye
Should hold her loathed, and his spirits should hunt
After new fancies: she, dying, gave it me,
And bid me, when my fate would have me wive,
To give it her. I did so; and take heed on't,
Make it a darling like your precious eye.
To lose't or give't away were such perdition
As nothing else could match.

DESDEMONA.
Is't possible?

OTHELLO.
'Tis true. There's magic in the web of it.
A sibyl, that had number'd in the world
The sun to course two hundred compasses,
In her prophetic fury sew'd the work;
The worms were hallow'd that did breed the silk,
And it was dyed in mummy, which the skillful
Conserv'd of maiden's hearts.

DESDEMONA.
Indeed? Is't true?

OTHELLO.
Most veritable, therefore look to 't well.

DESDEMONA.
Then would to God that I had never seen 't!

OTHELLO.
Ha? wherefore?

DESDEMONA.

Why do you speak so startingly and rash?

OTHELLO.
Is't lost? is't gone? speak, is it out of the way?

DESDEMONA.
Heaven bless us!

OTHELLO.
Say you?

DESDEMONA.
It is not lost, but what and if it were?

Glosses

Word or phrase	A short help
charmer	a woman with magic; an enchanter
amiable	worthy of love
perdition	ruin, damnation
sibyl	a prophetess
prophetic fury	a sacred, violent inspiration
hallow'd	made holy
mummy	a medicinal substance, said here to be conserved from hearts
startingly and rash	abruptly, and too fast
what and if it were?	a hypothetical: and even if it were lost?

III.4, after Othello's exit. *(Gutenberg 1531, lines 3691-3701.)*

DESDEMONA.
Alas the day, I never gave him cause!

EMILIA.
But jealous souls will not be answer'd so;
They are not ever jealous for the cause,
But jealous for they are jealous: 'tis a monster
Begot upon itself, born on itself.

DESDEMONA.
Heaven keep that monster from Othello's mind!

Gloss. *Begot upon itself*: born from itself; it does not need the cause it pretends to investigate.

Your tasks

1. Emilia's « I know not, madam. » What does the audience know? What kind of line is this (length, tone, a refused knowledge)?
2. The moist-hand speech over-reads a body. Copy one humoral word (*moist*, *liberal*, *hot*) and one moral word (*devil*, *castigation*, *heraldry*). In four sentences, say how a physical sign is turned into a verdict.
3. Desdemona returns the hand to the wedding: « 'twas that hand that gave away my heart. » In two sentences, say what Othello does *not* hear.
4. The history of the handkerchief: argue, with evidence, among three hypotheses: family lore told in good faith; a tactical curse-narrative; a man already so inside the plot that he sacralises the gift. You may combine two, but you must quote.
5. « It is not lost, but what and if it were? » Why is the grammar innocent, and why is it fatal in this scene?
6. Emilia sees the monster « begot upon itself » and still does not speak the fact of the theft. In three lines, name the third failure of trust.

Speaking turn. Direct either the aside « O, hardness to dissemble! » or the later triple cry « The handkerchief! » (read it in your edition). One decision about pause, volume, or address.

Written record. 220 to 250 words: « In III.4, how does Shakespeare test, and then unmake, three kinds of trust? »

Expanding your vocabulary

handkerchief (and *napkin* in some cues); charmer; sibyl; prophetic fury; mummy; perdition; liberal; heraldry; frank; to sequester; to dissemble; aside; self-begotten; to over-read; ekphrasis (description that installs a meaning).

Grammar for commentary

The hypothetical under pressure: *Desdemona's « what and if it were? » is grammatically innocent; in Othello's new grammar of proof, the mere admission of a possible loss already weighs as a confession.*

Stopping point · Emergency exit

A short commentary in four moves: Emilia's lie; one sentence of the moist-hand speech; « magic in the web »; « jealous for they are jealous ». One concluding sentence on trust.

Homework

1. Finish a fair copy of today's written record (250 words, C1).
2. Read IV.1 up to Bianca's entrance with the handkerchief.
3. Prepare the midpoint assessment (below): a timed commentary. Revise I.3, III.3 and III.4.

After your own reading: a model in short moves

1. The scene opens in almost brutal dramatic irony. Emilia's « I know not, madam » is a lie dressed as ignorance. Trust is first broken here by the waiting-woman, not by Othello.
2. Desdemona's « true of mind » is a profession of faith spoken just before the test. She is about to meet a man who has, in III.3, accepted a new way of reading.
3. The aside « O, hardness to dissemble! » shows, in one breath, the public face and the private strain.
4. The moist-hand speech is an over-reading of the body. A humoral commonplace (*hot*, *moist*, *liberal*) is moralised into a « young and sweating devil » seated in the palm. The method is Iago's, applied now to flesh.
5. Desdemona returns the hand to the wedding. Othello climbs into sententia: « our new heraldry is hands, not hearts. » The line could be wise in another mouth. Here it is used against the woman who has just given him her heart's explanation.

6. The Egyptian tale *installs* a meaning in an object. Whether the story is family truth, intimidation, or a mix Othello can no longer undo, is a question the scene asks. What is certain is dramaturgical: the gift is no longer a gift. It is a warrant of chastity.
7. « What and if it were? » belongs to a world in which love can survive a loss. Othello no longer lives in that world. Speech then shrinks to a command: « The handkerchief! »
8. Emilia diagnoses jealousy as self-begotten, and still does not speak. Three trusts fail together. III.4 is not a scene about a lost accessory. It is the scene in which the method of III.3 is applied to a body, a gift and a conversation.

Midpoint assessment (after Lesson 5, 55 minutes, timed on 52)

Commentary. « In Act III, scene 4, how does Shakespeare make a hand, a handkerchief and a change of subject into instruments of a trap of perception? »

Write a structured commentary: an introduction with a precise thesis, two or three parts, a conclusion that opens onto the guiding question. Quote accurately from the public-domain text. A C1 script will treat verse and device, not only character and feelings.

Emergency exit, at minute 44 if needed. A short commentary on *either* the moist-hand speech *or* « It is not lost, but what and if it were? », with a three-sentence opening and a three-sentence close.

A marking grid is given at the end of this booklet, and in the teacher’s and correction sheets. The midpoint is not the baccalaureate paper. It trains the gesture that Lesson 10 will ask for at full length.

Lesson 6. Directing the spectator

Turn. How can a scene be directed before anyone speaks? Staging and interpretation.

Aim. To read IV.1 as a scene whose meaning has been prepared for the man who is made to watch it.

> ***Before you read.*** *Othello is withdrawn, and Iago has told him what the next conversation will mean. What does it mean to watch a scene whose caption has already been written?*

IV.1, Othello as spectator. *(Gutenberg 1531, lines 4076-4121.)*

OTHELLO.
Iago beckons me. Now he begins the story.

CASSIO.
She was here even now. She haunts me in every place. I was the other day talking on the sea-bank with certain Venetians, and thither comes the bauble, and falls thus about my neck.

OTHELLO.
Crying, « O dear Cassio! » as it were: his gesture imports it.

CASSIO.
So hangs, and lolls, and weeps upon me; so hales and pulls me. Ha, ha, ha!

OTHELLO.
Now he tells how she plucked him to my chamber. O, I see that nose of yours, but not that dog I shall throw it to.

CASSIO.
Well, I must leave her company.

IAGO.
Before me! look where she comes.

Enter Bianca.

CASSIO.
'Tis such another fitchew! Marry, a perfum'd one.
What do you mean by this haunting of me?

BIANCA.
Let the devil and his dam haunt you! What did you mean by that same handkerchief you gave me even now? I was a fine fool to take it. I must take out the work? A likely piece of work, that you should find it in your chamber and not know who left it there! This is some minx's token, and I must take out the work? There, give it your hobby-horse. Wheresoever you had it, I'll take out no work on't.

CASSIO.
How now, my sweet Bianca? How now, how now?

OTHELLO.
By heaven, that should be my handkerchief!

BIANCA.
If you'll come to supper tonight, you may. If you will not, come when
you are next prepared for.

Glosses

Word or phrase	A short help
beckons	signals him to come close, or to watch
bauble	a toy; here, a contemptuous word for Bianca
his gesture imports it	the bodily movement is taken to mean that
to hale	to pull, to drag
fitchew	a polecat; a coarse insult
take out the work	copy the embroidery
minx's token	a gift from another woman, in Bianca's reading
hobby-horse	a further insult; a woman treated as a plaything

Your tasks

1. Who can hear what? Make a simple three-column table: *Othello hears / Cassio is in fact talking about / Iago has prepared*.
2. Copy two of Othello's asides or interpolations (« Now he begins the story »; « his gesture imports it »; « that should be my handkerchief »). For each, say what he adds to the scene in front of him.
3. Bianca treats the handkerchief as a piece of work that can be copied, and as someone else's token. In four sentences, contrast her reading of the object with Othello's reading in III.4.
4. In three lines: how has Shakespeare made us watch a man watching, and why is that more than a plot device?

Speaking turn. Place two readers (Cassio, Bianca) and one spectator (Othello). The spectator may only speak Othello's interpolations. Then justify the distance you chose.

Written record. 200 to 220 words: « How does Shakespeare make Othello a spectator of his own deception in IV.1? »

Expanding your vocabulary

to direct (a scene, and a spectator); interpolation; to beckon; to import (to mean, to imply); referent (what a speech is actually about); assigned meaning; to watch / to witness / to spy.

Grammar for commentary

A sentence that keeps three positions: *While Cassio speaks of Bianca, Othello, already instructed by Iago, attaches each gesture to Desdemona.*

Stopping point · Emergency exit

Iago has already… Cassio is speaking of… Othello hears… The handkerchief, for Bianca, is…; for Othello, it is…

Homework

1. Fair copy (220 words).
2. Re-read the Bianca exchange. Lesson 7 returns to one conversation with two meanings.

After your own reading: a model in short moves

1. The trap is ready before Bianca enters. « Now he begins the story » shows a spectator who thinks he is hearing a caption, not a conversation.
2. Cassio's « bauble » and laughter have a referent: Bianca. Othello supplies another: Desdemona. The same gestures are made to carry a story prepared offstage.
3. Bianca's entrance seems to confirm the story, because she brings the handkerchief. She also *refuses* the sacred meaning of III.4: for her, it is work to be copied, or another woman's token.
4. « That should be my handkerchief! » is a recognition and a misreading at once. The object is his; the story he attaches to it is not.
5. We are made spectators of a spectator. That is the lesson's formal heart: theatre showing how looking can be directed.

Lesson 7. One conversation, two meanings

Turn. Can two people share a conversation and not share its meaning? Referent and assigned story.

Aim. To return to IV.1 and name, with precision, how one dialogue can carry two referents at once.

The extract is the same complete passage as in Lesson 6. Keep it open. Today the work is not the first shock of watching, but a careful map of meaning.

> ***Before you re-read.*** *If you had to explain the mechanism to someone who had not seen the scene, which three facts would you have to state first?*

Your tasks

1. Write a six-line « score » of the exchange, in a table with four columns: *Line (short cue) / Cassio's referent / What Iago wants Othello to hear / What Othello says or assumes*.
2. Find one sentence of Cassio's that is, in his mouth, coarse or comic, and show how it becomes, in Othello's hearing, a proof.
3. Bianca's « I must take out the work » is practical. In three sentences, say why that practical meaning cannot reach Othello now.
4. In five lines, answer the turn of the spiral: can two people share a conversation and not share its meaning? Use the words *referent* and *assigned story* once each, accurately.

Speaking turn. Sixty seconds, without notes if you can: explain the mechanism to the class, with two quotations.

Written record. The table of task 1, plus a 150-word paragraph (task 4).

Expanding your vocabulary

referent; assigned story; to overhear; dramatic irony; confirmation (apparent); to map a dialogue; coarse / literal / symbolic (of a reading).

Grammar for commentary

Keep the two hearers in one sentence, without confusion: *The line is, for Cassio, about Bianca; it is received, by Othello, as a sentence upon Desdemona.*

Stopping point · Emergency exit

Three facts only, then one quotation: *Cassio is speaking of… Iago has told Othello… Therefore the same words… For example: « … »*

Homework

1. Fair copy of the table and the paragraph.
2. Read V.2, from the beginning (the light) to Desdemona's waking, and the closing speech « Soft you; a word or two… » to « And smote him, thus. »

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Lesson 8. The language of justification

Turn. How can murder be made to sound like justice? Rhetoric and justification.

Aim. To read two complete speeches in V.2: the soliloquy at the bed, and the last public self-portrait.

Before you read. *A man is about to kill, and he speaks of cause, justice, light and love. What work is the rhetoric doing?*

V.2, Othello, at the bed. *(Gutenberg 1531, lines 5472-5497.)*

It is the cause, it is the cause, my soul,
Let me not name it to you, you chaste stars!
It is the cause. Yet I'll not shed her blood,
Nor scar that whiter skin of hers than snow,
And smooth as monumental alabaster.
Yet she must die, else she'll betray more men.
Put out the light, and then put out the light:
If I quench thee, thou flaming minister,
I can again thy former light restore,
Should I repent me. But once put out thy light,
Thou cunning'st pattern of excelling nature,
I know not where is that Promethean heat
That can thy light relume. When I have pluck'd thy rose,
I cannot give it vital growth again,
It must needs wither. I'll smell it on the tree.

[Kissing her.]

O, balmy breath, that dost almost persuade
Justice to break her sword! One more, one more.
Be thus when thou art dead, and I will kill thee,
And love thee after. One more, and this the last.
So sweet was ne'er so fatal. I must weep,
But they are cruel tears. This sorrow's heavenly,
It strikes where it doth love. She wakes.

Glosses

Word or phrase	A short help
the cause	the justifying reason, named as if it were already a law
monumental alabaster	the white stone of tombs
flaming minister	the lamp, a servant of light
to relume	to light again
Promethean heat	the fire of life, stolen in myth by Prometheus

Word or phrase	A short help
fatal	both deadly and fated
This sorrow's heavenly	grief dressed as a sacred duty

V.2, the last speech. *(Gutenberg 1531, lines 6233-6254.)*

Soft you; a word or two before you go.
I have done the state some service, and they know't.
No more of that. I pray you, in your letters,
When you shall these unlucky deeds relate,
Speak of me as I am. Nothing extenuate,
Nor set down aught in malice. Then must you speak
Of one that loved not wisely, but too well;
Of one not easily jealous, but being wrought,
Perplex'd in the extreme; of one whose hand,
Like the base Judean, threw a pearl away
Richer than all his tribe; of one whose subdu'd eyes,
Albeit unused to the melting mood,
Drop tears as fast as the Arabian trees
Their medicinal gum. Set you down this.
And say besides, that in Aleppo once,
Where a malignant and a turban'd Turk
Beat a Venetian and traduc'd the state,
I took by the throat the circumcised dog,
And smote him, thus.

[Stabs himself.]

Glosses

Word or phrase	A short help
to extenuate	to lessen, to soften the facts
aught	anything
being wrought	having been worked upon
perplex'd	thrown into confusion
the base Judean	a much discussed reading; a man who throws away a pearl
medicinal gum	a healing resin, here an image for tears
to traduce	to slander, to wrong the state

Your tasks

1. In the bed soliloquy, circle every word of *justice* or *duty* (*cause*, *justice*, *must*, *heavenly*). Then circle every word of *tenderness* (*snow*, *rose*, *balmy*, *love*, *sweet*). In four sentences, say how the two vocabularies are made to work together.

2. « Put out the light, and then put out the light. » This is a word turned, in the turning, from lamp to life (a form of *anadiplosis* and of *antanaclasis*). In three lines, say what the repetition does.
3. In the last speech, Othello asks to be spoken of « as I am ». List the portraits he then offers (*loved not wisely*, *not easily jealous*, the pearl, Aleppo…). In five sentences: is this lucidity, or a last piece of self-fashioning, or both?
4. Connect one line from today with I.3 (« This only is the witchcraft I have us'd ») or with « I am not what I am ». One short paragraph.

Speaking turn. The seven lines from « Put out the light » to « I'll smell it on the tree ». One pause, justified from the verse.

Written record. 220 words: « How does V.2 make murder sound like justice, and what happens to that rhetoric in the last speech? »

Expanding your vocabulary

justification; rhetoric; cause; to quench / to relume; anadiplosis; to extenuate; to be wrought upon; self-portrait; lucidity; pathos.

Grammar for commentary

A balanced judgement: *The speech asks for justice, and it also arranges a pathos that makes the killing sound like a sacrifice.*

Stopping point · Emergency exit

« The cause » names… « Put out the light » turns… In the last speech Othello asks… He then describes himself as… This is / is not only lucidity because…

Homework

1. Fair copy (220 words).
2. For Lesson 9, read the short critics' table that opens the next lesson. Choose one critic you will answer in class.

After your own reading: a model in short moves

1. « It is the cause » is repeated as if repetition could make a law. The cause is not named to the stars. Naming it would already risk a trial of evidence.
2. Beauty (*snow*, *alabaster*, *rose*) is not a hesitation that stops the deed. It is folded into the justification: she must die, and she is made to look like a monument.
3. « Put out the light, and then put out the light » shows the method in little. A word is turned from lamp to life. He still knows the second light cannot be restored. He kills with that knowledge, not in ignorance of it.
4. The last speech wants a record: « Speak of me as I am. » The portraits that follow are shaped, even eloquent. « Not easily jealous, but being wrought » is almost true, and almost a softening.
5. The stroke at Aleppo turns a public service into a private execution, upon himself. The last theatre is still theatre: a meaning arranged to be believed, this time about the speaker.

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Lesson 9. What can literature teach?

Turn. Does literature educate judgement, or only show its limits? Critique and responsibility.

Aim. To read short public-domain critics and answer them; to compare one passage with François-Victor Hugo; to hold a C1 debate that is not a mere exchange of opinions.

Modern critics (T. S. Eliot, F. R. Leavis, Northrop Frye, René Girard, Stephen Greenblatt) may be named as invitations to further reading. They are not quoted at length, because their work is not in the public domain.

> ***Before you read the critics.*** *A critic is not an authority to hide behind. What would it mean to answer one accurately, with a line from the play?*

Thomas Rymer*, A Short View of Tragedy *(1693). His attack is hostile and useful. He treats the play, in substance, as a « Bloody Farce », and he mocks the weight placed on the handkerchief.

A C1 response does not simply call Rymer unkind. It asks what he has seen (the apparent disproportion between a piece of cloth and a murder) and what he has refused to see (that the cloth is not the cause, but the object onto which a method of reading has been forced). Lesson 5 is the best preparation for answering him.

Samuel Johnson*, *notes on* Othello *(1765). Johnson sets « the fiery openness of Othello, magnanimous, artless, and credulous, boundless in his confidence, ardent in his affection, inflexible in his resolution, and obdurate in his revenge » against « the cool malignity of Iago, silent in his resentment, subtle in his designs, and studious at once of his interest and his vengeance ».

Test the word *credulous*: after I.3, is Othello a man easy to deceive, or a man whose absolute trust (« My life upon her faith ») has been taken as a tool?

S. T. Coleridge*, *notes on* Othello *(early nineteenth century). On Iago, Coleridge speaks of « the motive-hunting of a motiveless malignity ». The phrase is famous because it is almost too good.

Use it, and also resist it: is malignity ever motiveless, or does Shakespeare show the hunt for motives as itself a performance, in keeping with « I am not what I am »?

William Hazlitt*, Characters of Shakespear's Plays *(1817). Hazlitt reads Shakespeare's figures as moral and theatrical energies. On Iago he insists on the intellect that serves injury.

A useful question: can we describe Iago's intelligence without being seduced into admiring it? The spectator's pact of Lesson 2 returns here as an ethical problem of criticism.

**A. C. Bradley*, Shakespearean Tragedy *(1904). Bradley calls Othello, « in one sense of the word, by far the most romantic figure among Shakespeare's heroes ». Unpack* romantic*: not a love-story commonplace, but a nature that lives at a height, trusts absolutely, and is therefore workable upon.

Later challenges (T. S. Eliot, F. R. Leavis) may be named, then you return to the verse.

François-Victor Hugo: a translation exercise

François-Victor Hugo, *Othello ou le More de Venise*, is the only French version used here. The exercise is not a hunt for errors. It is a study of choices.

> ***English (I.1), public-domain text:***
>
> *For when my outward action doth demonstrate*
> *The native act and figure of my heart*
> *In complement extern, 'tis not long after*
> *But I will wear my heart upon my sleeve*
> *For daws to peck at: I am not what I am.*

Compare Hugo's rendering of the last clause and of « wear my heart upon my sleeve », from a public-domain edition (Wikisource or a nineteenth-century printing). If the classroom copy differs, the teacher provides the corresponding lines.

Your tasks

1. In pairs, take one critic. Produce: one accurate paraphrase (three lines); one resistance (three lines); one quotation from the play that answers him.
2. Plenary: fill a comparative table: *critic / what he sees / what he misses / a line that answers him*.
3. Hugo, written:

- What does Hugo do with « I am not what I am »? Does the French keep the inversion, or choose clarity over echo? - What image does he offer for « wear my heart upon my sleeve », and what is gained or lost? - In one paragraph (150 words, in English): what does a translation reveal about the theatrical contract of the line?

1. Optional, for a stronger group: the moist-hand speech and Hugo's treatment of *liberal*, *sweating devil*, and « our new heraldry is hands, not hearts ».

Speaking turn. « I answer Rymer (or Johnson, or Coleridge) by saying… » Forty seconds, one quotation from *Othello*.

Written record. The Hugo paragraph, and five lines of the comparative table.

Expanding your vocabulary

judgement; farce; malignity; credulous; magnanimous; artless (without artifice); obdurate; motive; to resist a critic; rendering; idiom; inversion; to unpack a term; responsibility (of the reader).

Grammar for commentary

Reporting a critic without surrendering one's voice: *Johnson's balance is just insofar as it names two tempos; it becomes insufficient when « credulous » is made to sound like a defect of intelligence rather than a form of trust*.

Stopping point · Emergency exit

Answer Rymer only: what he saw about the handkerchief, and what Lesson 5 taught you to reply.

Homework

Prepare Lesson 10. Revise the model close readings (I.1, I.3, III.4, IV.1, V.2). The commentary question and the director's oral task are printed below. No new reading.

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Lesson 10. Explaining the trap

Turn. Can we explain the trap without being trapped by our own reading? Explanation and humility.

Aim. To write a full commentary, and to speak a short director's commentary, without pretending that one reading closes the play.

Summative written task (the heart of the hour)

Commentary. « How does Shakespeare make Othello a spectator of his own deception, and what does that trap still teach us about language, jealousy and the courage to read between the lines? »

You may centre the argument on IV.1, but you are expected to look back (I.1, I.3, III.3, III.4) and, if you wish, forward to V.2. Introduction with a precise thesis; two or three parts; a conclusion that opens, without grandstanding, onto the guiding question. Quote accurately. Treat verse and device.

Timing: the written task occupies most of the hour. At minute 44, if you are in difficulty, complete a shorter commentary on IV.1 only, with a firm opening and a firm close.

Summative oral task (director's commentary)

Two to three minutes, after the written work or in a later slot if the class needs it.

You are the director of IV.1 (or of III.4, if you argued that scene more strongly). Explain one choice of space, one choice of address or silence, and one thing you would refuse to illustrate (no additional « proof » invented for the eye). Justify each decision from the verse.

After the scripts: the tip

If time remains, or in a short closing exchange:

When a society believes images and rumours rather than facts and persons, who becomes the victim, and why?

The three paths (existential, political, civilisational) are not slogans. They are ways of taking the play back into a life that is not the play.

Expanding your vocabulary (last revision)

trap of perception; to direct a spectator; ocular proof; to over-read; assigned meaning; trust; to extenuate; judgement; humility (of a reading); device (and what it does).

Homework

A fair copy of the commentary, if the teacher asks for one, or a one-page director's note. No new text.

Assessment grids (student-facing)

Midpoint commentary (after Lesson 5)

Criterion	What a C1 script does
Thesis	A precise claim about III.4, not a retelling of the plot.
Use of the text	Accurate quotation; line or cue given; the quote is *used*, not dropped in.
Devices	At least two are named and shown at work (aside, irony, sententia, ekphrasis, hypothetical…).
Argument	Two or three parts that move; no long paraphrase.
Language	Controlled British English; cautious verbs (*suggests*, *installs*, *does not prove*).

Summative commentary (Lesson 10)

The same five criteria, with a wider range of scenes and a conclusion that opens onto the guiding question without a slogan. The oral director's commentary is marked for: one spatial choice, one vocal or silent choice, one refusal, each justified from the verse.

A small bank of sentence starters (C1)

- The line does not only mean…; it also…
- The audience already holds a fact that…
- What looks like proof is in fact…
- The object does not carry a single essence; it carries…
- Iago's method is to…
- A cautious reading will not claim more than…
- The device *X* does *Y* in this speech because…
- This is not a scene about…, but about…

A short bibliography and a note on editions

Shakespeare, *Othello*, public-domain English text, Project Gutenberg ebook 1531. In class, the Folger Shakespeare Library Digital Text is an excellent working edition for line numbers.

François-Victor Hugo, *Othello ou le More de Venise*, public domain. The only French translation used here.

Thomas Rymer, *A Short View of Tragedy* (1693); Samuel Johnson, notes in *The Plays of William Shakespeare* (1765); S. T. Coleridge, notes on Shakespeare; William Hazlitt, *Characters of Shakespear's Plays* (1817); A. C. Bradley, *Shakespearean Tragedy* (1904). All public domain.

Théodore Chassériau, *Othello et Desdémone à Venise*, 1849-1850, Musée du Louvre, Paris, RF 3897, public domain.

Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.

Editorial note

Line numbers in the extracts follow Project Gutenberg ebook 1531, so that every class can find the same public-domain words. They will not always match a modern through-line numbering (Folger, Arden, Oxford). That is not a defect of the booklet. It is a reason to keep both a public text and a working school edition on the desk.

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